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SONGS IN THE FORT

Jodhpur RIFF 2025 blends local traditions and global sounds in a celebration of music and culture



SOUL FOOD (Second from right) Bhutanese artist Kheng Sonam Dorji and his co-performers

Mehrangarh Fort will once again transform into the epicentre of global roots music as Jodhpur RIFF (Rajasthan International Folk Festival) returns for its 18th edition from October 2–6. Known for its dramatic setting and thoughtful curation, the festival gathers artists from Rajasthan, Bhutan, Uzbekistan, Portugal, Finland, Colombia and more—offering audiences music that



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SONIC ALCHEMY

WITH *LEATHER & BRASS*, ELECTRONIC MUSICIAN SIJYA TRANSFORMS VULNERABILITY INTO TEXTURED SOUNDSCAPES, MARKING HER BOLDEST ARTISTIC EVOLUTION YET

On September 12, New Delhi-based composer, producer and visual artist Sijya released her sophomore EP *Leather & Brass* via UK label One Little Independent Records, becoming the first Indian artist to join the iconic roster, best known for its long-time association with Björk. A bold and emotionally intricate work, the EP builds on the introspective groundwork laid in her 2022 debut *Young Hate*, while signalling a shift towards greater intention and sonic precision.

Described by Sijya as both painful and transformative, the process behind *Leather & Brass* involved cycles of experimentation and failure. "As artists, we know what we want to improve, but sometimes we discover blind spots we didn't even know existed," she reflects. Having sought feedback from peers and mentors, including Jay Panelia, Amaan Khan and her former label Accidental Records, Sijya said, "I knew I had to 'level up'. It was humbling and exhausting, but that's why I'm proud of this project, I know how far it's come."

Dreamy synth layers collide with delicate vocal lines in the EP, prioritising emotional resonance over literal meaning. "It's really quite reductive to say what a song is about," she says. "If something can be explained so easily, why make a four-minute work about it?" Her music resists the contemporary urge for clarity and invites listeners to excavate meaning for themselves.

Tracks like 'Rust' and 'I only want to crash' embody this ethos, while others, like 'Safe' and 'Why do you fight me', examine themes of anger, resistance and vulnerability. With engineers like Seth Manchester and Panelia helping shape its analogue warmth, *Leather & Brass* emerged as a textural and emotional evolution. Its artwork, a reworked childhood photo, mirrors this transformation. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

A BOLD DELICACY (Left) *Leather & Brass* and electronic musician Sijya

